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Santorini

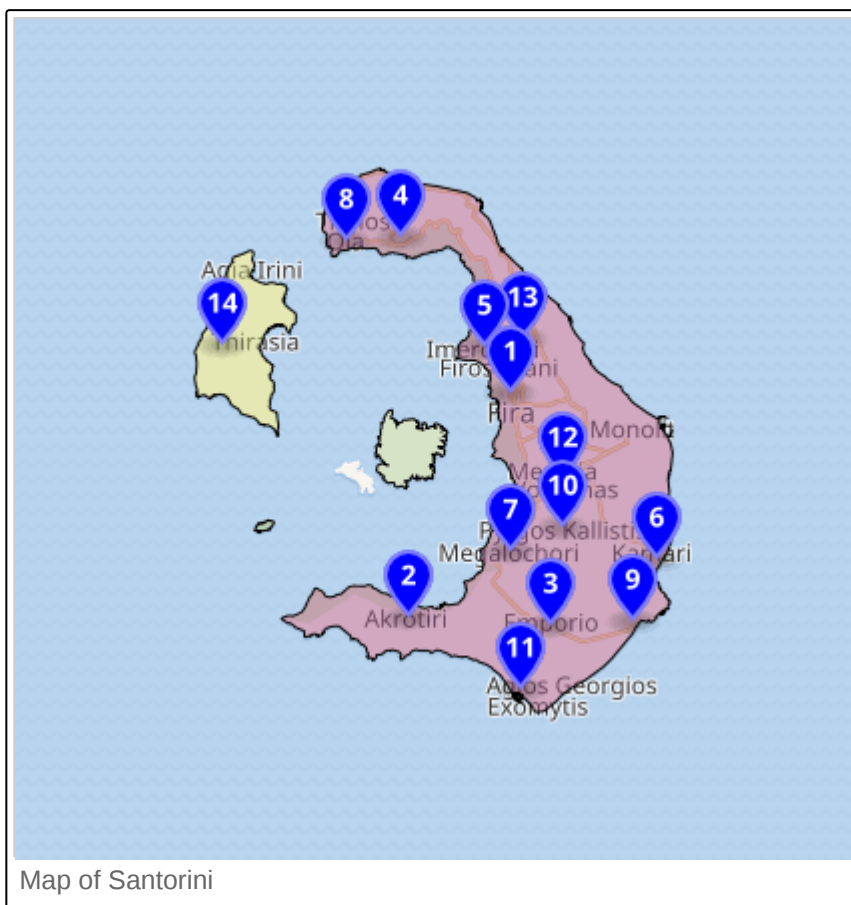
Santorini is an archipelago of 5 volcanic islands in the [Cyclades](#) group of the [Greek](#) islands in the southern Aegean Sea, about 200 km southeast of mainland Greece. It used to be a single island, but was obliterated around 1600 BCE by an enormous volcanic explosion that destroyed the earliest settlements on the former island and created the current geological caldera. It is famous for dramatic views, stunning sunsets from white clifftop villages, the ancient city ruins of [Thera](#) and [Akrotiri](#), unique wines, artists and craftsmen, an active volcano, and strikingly colorful pebble beaches.

Islands

Thira

By far the largest (73 km²) and most populous (15,500 people) of the islands, often confusingly called *Santorini* itself. Almost all accommodation and tourist infrastructure is on Thira, and it is where the vast majority of visitors arrive and stay.

- **1 Fira** — the capital city and tourist hub of Santorini, this stunning cliff-perched town has many museums and cultural venues.
- **2 Akrotiri** — famous for the ruins of a Bronze Age Minoan settlement, charming



lighthouse, and Venetian Castle.

- **3 Emporio** — second largest town on Thira, with narrow cobblestone streets and Venetian castle on top of a hill, as well as one of the best preserved marble temples.
- **4 Finikia** — a beautiful, well-preserved traditional village with 2 volcanic cones in its backyard. All dazzling white or colourful houses and notable churches are carved on the volcanic rocks, its Cycladic architecture takes visitors to another time.
- **5 Imerovigli** — popular coastal town overlooking the caldera.
- **6 Kamari** — a cozy town with black sand beach. On top of the nearby hill are the ruins of Ancient Thera.
- **7 Megalochori** — a traditional village with a lot of old white Cycladic churches that is famous for its wineries.
- **8 Oia** — this restored traditional settlement is world famous (and overrun by tourists) for its lovely sunsets. Its charming cube-like houses with colourful façades are perched on the edge of the 150 m cliffs.
- **9 Perissa** — has churches from all eras of civilisation, and good Greek fish restaurants.
- **10 Pyrgos** — highest point on the island, with a picturesque monastery, a Venetian castle and narrow streets.
- **11 Vlychada** — fishing village on the southern shore, with nude beach and large marina.
- **12 Vothonas** — a small village in a ravine, and centre of Santorini's wine industry. All the buildings were cut from the ravine that it is in.
- **13 Vourvoulos** — inland town known for its vineyards.



Thirasia

The second largest inhabited island in the archipelago, with an area of 9 km² and less than 500 inhabitants.

- **14 Thirasia** — the largest village on the island

Nea Kameni

The centre of the Santorini volcano, this circular island with a diameter of about 2 km is a barren volcanic rock with a crater in its centre and sulphur vents all around. Can be reached from Thira with ferries and excursion ships.

Palea Kameni

The youngest island of the archipelago, Palea Kameni appeared around 2 millennia ago, and its birth was documented by Roman scientist Cassius Dio in 47 BCE. Palea Kameni has a single inhabitant, Sostice Arvanitis, who is a goat herder and keeper on the island. The only points of interest on this small barren island are a church and hot spring.

Aspronisi

The smallest island in the archipelago, with a length of only 650 m. It is uninhabited, with steep cliffs that make approaching from the water difficult and hazardous. Aspronisi does have two pebble beaches and a disused anchorage, but there are no scheduled ferry services from any of the other islands. The name means *white island*,



referring to the colour of the volcanic pumice that makes up most of what is visible above the waterline.

The **Christiana Islands** (Christiani, Eschati, and Askania) about 20 km southwest of Santorini are sometimes counted as part of the archipelago, but actually are a separate group of islands. They have remained uninhabited since the late 19th century, although the largest of the islands does have archaeological evidence of a Neolithic settlement. They are privately owned, and there are no scheduled ferry services to them.

Understand

Santorini is between Ios and Anafi islands in the southern Cyclades. On a clear day, you may be able to see Crete, about 100 km to the south. The name is a contraction of *Saint Irene*, after an old church in Perissa.

The Santorini archipelago used to be a single island, until a volcanic eruption around 1600 BCE tore it apart. The eruption was among the most massive in human history. There is a local legend that Santorini was once home to the Lost City of Atlantis, destroyed by the eruption. Most historians dispute this claim, but the myth's parallels to Santorini's explosive past are tantalizing. Eruptions still occur; the central Nea Kameni has grown substantially in modern times, as recently as 1950.



View of Fira

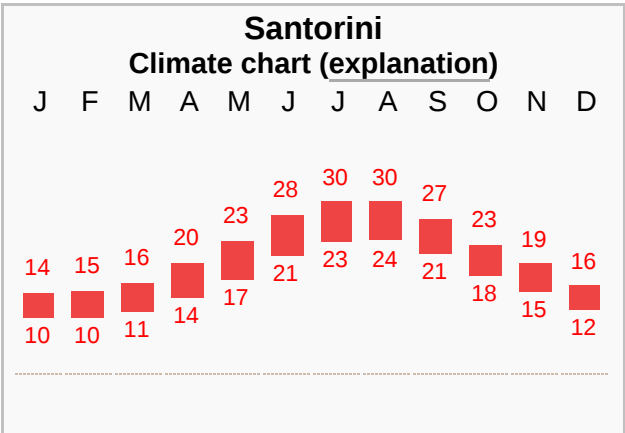


The eruption left behind today's **caldera**, an expansive crater rimmed by three fragments that survived the eruption, filled in with sea water and the two newer islands. The interior caldera walls are steep, up to 300 m high, and mostly impassable, although a number of villages are built along its ridge. It is one of the most distinctive landscapes in the entire Mediterranean.

Traditional Cycladic architecture — dense clusters of cubic whitewashed stone buildings — fills most of the villages, interspersed with villas and wineries. Much of the island has been restored since a major earthquake in 1956, which spurred this relatively remote outpost to rebuild itself into the iconic tourism destination it is today.

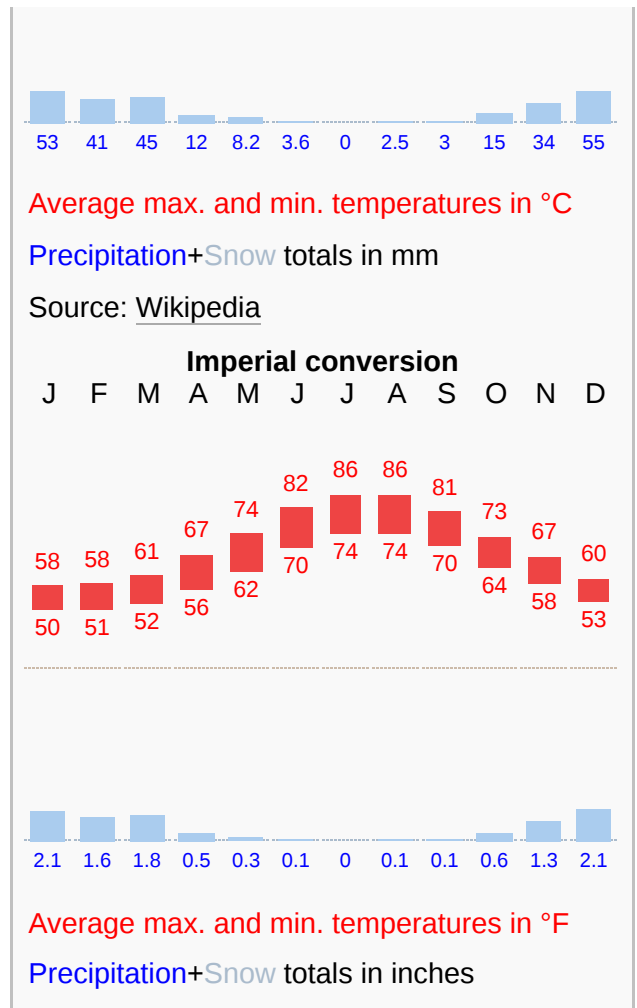
Climate

In April and May, temperatures are pleasant and the chance of rain is low, which is ideal to hike from one town to the other, such as the famous Fira - Oia hiking trail. Wildflowers blossom and the otherwise barren islands turn into a colourful sea of wild flowers. After May, temperatures soar with an extreme UV index: summers are extremely hot. With very few trees to provide shade, the weather becomes too hot to do anything but stay inside the cooler cave houses. Public



life slows down, restaurants and amenities close during the hottest hours of the day (noon - 15:00), and the beautiful spring flowers are scorched away with only dried out grasses left. From September, the weather becomes cooler again and more attractive for a visit, although the chance of rain also gradually increases towards the end of the year — Santorini receives most of its annual precipitation during the winter months.

For milder weather, prices and crowds, the **ideal times to visit are the shoulder seasons** of April–June and September–October. The 'season' starts April 1, or around the Greek Easter. In the summer, not only is the region unpleasantly hot, but it is also overcrowded with cruise ships and beach-goers. Seasonal businesses start closing for the season towards the end of October, and by December most businesses, including hotels and guest houses, are shuttered until spring. December through March is very much the off-season and marked by cooler temperatures with occasional rain and winds. While Fira stays more-or-less open and supports over a dozen year-round restaurants, smaller villages may only have one or two places open. Although it is rare for the temperatures to get very low, the poor weather makes for a less than optimal experience on this beautiful island.



Watch and listen

Due to the spectacular and unique natural beauty of Santorini, many Greek singers have chosen the island as the setting of their videos. Greek and Brazilian TV series have been shot of Santorini, as well as some Hollywood movies (*e.g.* Tomb Raider II). Generally Santorini is a pole of attraction for Greek and international celebrities.

World-famous Greek composer Yanni wrote the song "Santorini", inspired by the beauty of the island. It is worth checking out, especially the version performed live at the Acropolis with the Royal Philharmonic Concert Orchestra.



Bells of the blue domed church
(dedicated to St. Spirou) in Firostefani

Tourist information

- [Santorini tourism \(http://www.santorini.gr/index.php?/en/\)](http://www.santorini.gr/index.php?/en/) website

Get in

The main options are ferries from Pireaus (standard ferryboats and high-speed catamarans) and flights from Athens.

Getting in from Athens by air is faster and you avoid possible sea sickness. However, in season air tickets sell out well before most of the ferries.

By plane

There are regular flights from Athens by Aegean Airlines, Sky Express, and Volotea, with a flight time of 30-45 minutes. Volotea also has a regular service from Thessaloniki.

From May till October many charter airlines fly directly to Santorini from many European airports. Listed below is commercial air service.

Seasonal and charter flights to Santorini
Aegean Airlines (http://www.aegeanair.com/) regular flights to <u>Athens</u> with seasonal to <u>Larnaca</u> and <u>Thessaloniki</u>
Aer Lingus (https://www.aerlingus.com/) flies twice weekly from Dublin between May and October inclusive
Air France flies seasonally from Paris (Charles de Gaulle)
Austrian Airlines flies seasonally from Vienna
Blue Panorama Airlines flies seasonally from Bergamo, Bologna, Rome-Fiumicino
British Airways flies seasonally from London's City Airport and London-Heathrow
Condor (http://www.condor.com/) flies seasonally from Düsseldorf, Frankfurt, and Munich
easyJet (http://www.easyjet.com/) flies seasonally from <u>Bristol</u> , <u>Geneva</u> , <u>London-Gatwick</u> , <u>Manchester</u> , <u>Milan-Malpensa</u> and <u>Venice</u>
Edelweiss Air (http://www.edelweissair.ch/) flies seasonally from Zurich
Eurowings (http://www.eurowings.com/) flies seasonally from Cologne/Bonn, Düsseldorf, Stuttgart, and Vienna
Finnair seasonally flies from Helsinki
Iberia Express seasonally flies from Madrid;
Jet2.com seasonally flies from Birmingham, Leeds/Bradford, London-Stansted, and Manchester;
LOT Polish Airlines seasonally flies from Krakow, Warsaw-Chopin, and Wroclaw;
Lufthansa seasonally flies from Frankfurt and Munich;
Neos seasonally flies from Milan-Malpensa and Verona;
Norwegian (http://www.norwegian.com) flies seasonally from Copenhagen, Oslo and Stockholm;
Olympic Air (http://www.olympicair.com/) flies from Athens and seasonally from Thessaloniki;
Qatar Airways seasonally flies from Doha;
Ryanair (http://www.ryanair.com/) flies seasonally from Athens, Bergamo, Dublin, <u>Milan</u> and Vienna;
Sky Express (https://www.skyexpress.gr/en/) flies seasonally from Athens;
Transavia (http://www.transavia.com/) flies seasonally from Amsterdam, Nantes, Paris-Orly.
TUI Airways flies seasonally from Brussels, Bristol, East Midlands, London-Gatwick, Manchester, and Newcastle upon Tyne;
Volotea flies from Athens year-round. Their seasonal routes include Bari, Bordeaux, Genoa, Lyon, Marseille, Nantes, Naples, Palermo, Thessaloniki, Toulouse, Venice, and Verona;
Vueling seasonally flies from Barcelona, Florence, and Rome-Fiumicino;
Wizz Air seasonally flies from Bucharest, Budapest, Dortmund, London-Luton, Milan-Malpensa, and Vienna.

1 Santorini (Thira) National Airport (<http://www.santorini-airport.com/>) (JTR ^{IATA}) (*north of Monolithos*). The airport is very small, so passengers are allowed to drop off their luggage only two hours before their flight. There is a large number of seats outside of the terminal with a cafeteria, where passengers may wait. In the gate areas, seating is very limited. There is a cafeteria upstairs with outdoor tables for a view of planes.

Getting there:

- From the airport there are **buses to Fira**, €2 (2025), where you can change to buses for other towns.

- **Taxis** are also usually waiting at the airport, but competition for them can be keen, €30-40 to Fira (2025).
- Many Santorini hotels offer **airport transfers**, usually for a fee that's more than a taxi would charge you, but some may find it worth it for the convenience.
- As the island is very small it's possible to **walk from the airport**, if you are fit enough (~5.5 km/90 min to the centre of Fira).

By boat

See also: Cyclades § By ferry

There are the standard ferryboats that need about 7–9 hours to reach Santorini from Piraeus and the fast ferries or high speed catamarans that take about 4–5 hours to reach the island. Check what you have bought: just because you have a reservation for a ferry, doesn't mean that you have a place to sit. Seats could be at extra cost.

Transport by sea is always *dependent on weather*. For safety, especially in winter or raining monsoon, cruise ships may delay or cancel landing shuttles, and ferries their departure times.



Panoramic view of the Catholic quarter of Fira

Take the ferry from Piraeus (port of Athens), past Paros and Naxos, to the new port on Thira. There is also a daily connection from Heraklion (Crete) during high season.

Ferries dock at the **2 port of Athinios**, where *buses* meet each arrival to transport passengers to Fira (trip takes 15 min and costs €2.3); taxis are also available. All vehicles climb a very steep, winding road (it makes seven 180 degree turns) to leave the port.

Cruise ships are often unable to dock at Athinios port due to size constraints, but instead anchor 3 km north in the caldera, west of Fira. Locals with fishing boats occasionally transfer cruisers to the **3 old port of Fira** (which seems not to have changed over the last 50 years), and larger, decorated shuttle boats take large-ship passengers to and from the docks below Fira.

There is no road from the old port. Instead, you can take a cable car up from the port (€10 each way) or take one of the hundreds of donkeys up the 588 zigzagging steps (also €10 each way). You could also attempt to walk up the steps but be warned, the stairs are winding, narrow in parts with only low walls, they are covered in donkey excrement, and the donkeys will make no attempt to avoid you.

Get around

By bus

KTEL Santorini (<http://www.ktel-santorini.gr/>), the public bus service, connects all points of the island with Fira, costing €2.00-2.80 one way (2025), depending on the route. This is probably the only cheap thing you'll find on the island considering the buses are comfy and air conditioned! Tickets can be

purchased on the bus, with cash only — so bring some coins. The fare collector can (usually) make change.

4 Fira Bus Station is the hub of the bus network, and almost all the lines "branch out" from this hub. This means, if you wish to go from one side of the island to another, you need to transfer at Fira and pay for the second leg of your journey.

There are no route numbers and not all buses display their routes; ask the drivers or the ticket office for the bus number that would take you to your destination.

The bus routes are:

- Oia (via Imerovigli & Firostefani)
- Perissa (via Pyrgos)
- Airport (via Karterados, Megaria). Some buses also continue to Monolithos.
- Kamari
- Akrotiri museum (via Megalochori & Akrotiri village)
- Ferry terminal

Schedules highly vary depending on the season, with low season services ending by 19:00 (even already until 15:00 weekends on all routes except Oia) and most buses running only every 90 minutes. During peak season, buses run up to every 15 minutes from/to popular spots such as Oia, Kamari, and Perissa, with services ending until midnight. The most recent timetables are obtainable at the KTEL website. Buses generally leave Fira on schedule, but can drift pretty far from the published return times.

There are also buses that travel to the ferry port, however their schedules are normally handwritten and displayed only at the Fira bus stop the day before, as ferry departure times are different every day; conversely there are always public buses standing by at the port upon the arrival of each ferry.

The buses occasionally miss trips, and some drivers are less than friendly. In peak season the buses would have already fill up at their starting points and will skip intermediate stops, so keep this in mind when considering where to stay. The buses are tourist coaches with luggage compartments for large backpacks or cases. When the bus is full however, you have to stand up at the corridor and it will be difficult to get off at an intermediate stop.

By boat

Boats run between major coastal towns in the archipelago, notably between Fira, Nea Kameni, Palea Kameni, and the old port of Thirassia. Tickets can be purchased at ticket offices in most of the ports. The ticket will list the port of departure, port of arrival, and the **number of the vessel** instead of its name. The vessel number is always printed on the lifeboats, when in doubt. A single journey between Fira and Thirassia starts at ~~€10~~ (Apr 2022). It's also possible to book a 6-hour "tour" around the caldera, which costs ~~€30~~ per person.

Larger boats have a bar where drinks and snacks can be purchased.

By car

Most of the people in Santorini are tourists, so road conditions are unsafe, with many people driving by the laws and conventions of nearly every country in the world. It takes about an hour to drive the island from end to end (from [Exomytis](#) to [Oia](#)).

Cars can be rented from about €40 a day during high season and from €20 during off season. An international driving permit is recommended. Without one, many car rental places will still rent to you, but you may have insurance problems in case of accident.

Scooters are available to rent starting at about €15 per day. A drivers license is required.

ATVs (quads or all-terrain-vehicles) are popular, though the "all-terrain" part is a misnomer, as most ATVs are only allowed to ride on roads. ATVs share the road with other drivers and are usually all over the island. The island is small enough to travel around on an ATV, and is a cost-effective way to self-explore the further reaches of Santorini. ATV rental shops are all around the island, so it's best to ask your hotel owner/concierge on the closest/most trusted vendor. You will need your driver's licence, and a helmet is recommended.

Some hotels advise booking a **taxi** in advance, as there are not enough available taxis on the island during high season. As is the rule in the Cyclades, taxi fares are typically shared between multiple passengers, so don't be surprised if your cabbie picks up more passengers during your trip.

By bicycle

The island is small enough to thoroughly explore by [bicycle](#). Bicycle rentals are fairly hard to find — most places advertising "bike" rentals refer instead to motorbikes — but are available from [Fira](#) and [Exomytis](#).

Santorini is not at all bicycle-friendly. There are no dedicated bicycle lanes, so you must share roads with vehicular traffic. In addition, the island is very hilly with a few steep mountains as well. Trails intended for hikers are generally impassable by bicycle.

By foot

In Santorini, you shall find pathways paved mostly with cobblestones and steps at the cliffside, so it is not the best place for heels or non-comfortable shoes. A pair of sneakers or comfy walking shoes will be ideal during your strolls around the island.

Recommended routes by foot include:

- the amazing walk from Fira to Oia (this walk is less nice in reverse, it can take less than three hours but can be difficult, for up and downhill climbs, the rocky surface at times, and the proximity to unprotected cliffs that drop sharply into the caldera) along the caldera
- the paths over Perissa Rock connecting Perissa, Kamari, and Pyrgos. The walk between Perissa and Kamari is fairly short (via Ancient Thira), while the walk to Pyrgos is somewhat



Night view of Oia



longer, passing through the highest point on the island.

See

For an archipelago its size, Santorini has a wealth of attractions to offer a curious traveller. From fascinating museums to Bronze Age city ruins to black sand beaches, Santorini is a worthwhile visit in every season.

Scenic villages

Fira is the fiery capital, a marriage of Venetian and Cycladic architecture, whose white cobblestone streets bustle with shops, tavernas, hotels and cafes, while clinging to the rim of the caldera 275 m (900 feet) above its port.

Just above Fira is Imerovigli, where you can take in the magnificent views of the island's unique scenery from the tiny town, as it is the highest point of the Caldera cliffs.

At the north end of the island is the quintessentially Santorinian town of Oia, also sometimes spelled Ia, with its whitewashed walls sunk into the volcanic rock and its blue domes rising above the sterling beauty of the stunning, russet Ammoudi Bay. At dusk, the town attracts crowds of people venturing to see the sunset, reputed to be among the world's most beautiful.



Houses in Oia



Nature

Santorini is one of the great natural wonders of the world, and its main attraction is its landscape and seascape. The configuration of the present, roughly semicircular archipelago is the result of an enormous volcanic explosion which occurred around 1600 BCE, literally blowing the top off the island and changing what had been a typical half-submerged mountain of an Aegean island into a flooded crescent caldera.

In the middle of the caldera is the volcanic island of **Nea Kameni**, which can be visited by a 20-minute ferry trip from Thira and allows adventurers to climb the slopes to peek into the smoking crater. Steam and sulphur vents can be observed along the way — from a safe distance, of course! Volcanic cones also survive on Thira itself, with **Mavro Vouno** and **Kokkino Vouno** climbable with hiking trails from Finikia. The steep cliffs of the caldera are a magnificent sight best enjoyed from a ship in the caldera. A climb up the cliff face is possible at Fira where the **Karavolades Stairs** lead into the caldera.



Climbing the slopes of Nea Kameni



Erosion of the volcanic cliffs leads to surprising geological formations such as Fira's **Skaros Rock**, which towers high above the water and is host to the ruins of a fort. The **Heart of Santorini** near Megalochori is another geological formation that has become a popular spot for photographers. The cliffs also form

countless bays of all shapes and sizes that used to be hide-outs for pirates, but in more modern times are beloved spots for watching Santorini's famed sunsets. The most idyllic is without a doubt **Amoudi Bay** in Oia, which also serves as a port from which ferries depart to Therasia, Santorini's second inhabited island that is worth a day trip of its own.

Archaeology

Santorini has been known since ancient times, and throughout the millennia has been inhabited by many civilisations. The south of Thira is home to two ancient cities, dating from different eras.

The oldest and scientifically most valuable is **Ancient Akrotiri**, a Bronze Age city built by the Minoans, who are best known from their heritage on Crete. When the volcano erupted and obliterated Santorini around 1600 BCE, the Minoan city was buried under volcanic pumice and ash — much like Pompeii — and incredibly well preserved. The entire city is covered with a giant canopy, so it can be comfortably visited even during the hot summer months.

The Phoenicians founded their own city on the island that was known to them as *Kalliste*, and promptly renamed it after their leader Theras. Thus, the island became known as Thera in ancient times, from which the modern name Thira was derived. The city of **Ancient Thera** survived for centuries and was known to be prosperous, as evidenced by gold coins and many archaeological artefacts that have been found during excavations. The ruins sit on Gavrilos Hill between Kamari and Perissa, and a visit is worth it for the view as well as for the history of the site.

The frequent seismic and volcanic activity in the archipelago unfortunately leaves few structures intact over geological time scales, but one remarkable exception is the **Temple of Agios Nikolaos Marmaritis**, a marble temple near Emporio that dates to the 3rd century. The square temple is only 4 m long and wide, and is still in use for liturgical purposes today.

The Santorini archipelago was conquered by the Venetians in 1207, and 5 fortified castles were constructed from the 13th century onward to protect the island from invaders, most notably the Ottomans with whom the Venetians were perpetually at war from 1396 until 1718. The largest of the castles is La Ponta in Akrotiri and the newest and best preserved is Pyrgos Castle, but if you have limited time, you might want to prioritise a visit to the 15th-century Castle of Emporio, which still forms the centre of present-day Emporio. The medieval castle boasts narrow streets and picturesque churches, with many fewer gift shops than in Fira or Oia.



Pottery in the courtyard of a house in Ancient Akrotiri. 



Ruins of Ancient Thera 



Fortifications of Pyrgos Castle. 

Museums

When the weather isn't as sunny as the travel brochures promise, there are quite a few alternatives indoor. Most of the museums are in [Fira](#). Confusingly, Fira has two different history museums: the **Museum of Prehistoric Thera**, which tells the story of the ancient Bronze Age settlement at Akrotiri, and the **Archaeological Museum of Thera**, that has a collection of pottery, amphora, and figures from the beginning of the Proto-Cycladic period of the 3rd millennium BC and continues on to the Classical period. There are also museums about naval history, tomatoes, wine, ethnography and other subjects.



Sculptures in the Archaeological Museum in [Fira](#). 

Architecture

Although the volcanic pumice quarries were decommissioned in the 1980s, the architectural style of square dwellings with white painted facades is still used consistently. The iconic blue roofs are not as common as one would think; they appear just about every postcard but in reality only a handful of churches actually have the blue roofs — all postcards use pictures of the same few buildings, but photographed from different angles!



Churches with iconic blue roofs in [Oia](#). 

Pumice is a natural insulating material because it is filled with little gas bubbles, and historically many houses were either partially built into the mountain side to take advantage of the insulation, or were built with underground cellars. The strategy is effective to keep heat out in summer, and keep houses warm in winter.

As iconic as the white walls and blue roofs are the **windmills**, which can be found all over the islands. There are two in [Oia](#), and a few east of Finikia as well as south of the island near [Emporio](#). Windmills in the same style can be found on many nearby Cyclades islands, but somehow they have stuck with Santorini's image. The windmill of Oia is the most photographed structure of Santorini.

At the other end of Thira, at Cape Akrotiri, the **Faros lighthouse** is a popular place to watch the sunset, and far less crowded with tourists. The lighthouse is still in active operation by the Greek Navy.

There appear to be a nearly endless number of churches on Santorini, along with several monasteries. Even Palea Kameni, one of the smallest islands in the archipelago, doesn't have any infrastructure or buildings except for... a church! Most of the churches are Greek Orthodox. Their bells, usually in groups of odd numbers such as 3 or 5, are typically mounted in a stepped wall. The **Three Bells of Fira** became particularly popular for no apparent reason, as there are many churches on Thira that have a similar bell configuration. The picture-perfect location on the ridge of the caldera may have something to do with it. Fira is also home to not only one, but two cathedrals, both of which are Christian but with different flavours: the **Cathedral of Saint John the Baptist** is Roman Catholic and was founded in 1204. Its bell

tower is a landmark of the city and worth a visit. The **Orthodox Metropolitan Cathedral** was built in 1827 when Roman Catholicism fell out of favour. It has a large courtyard and beautifully decorated interior.

The **Profeta Elías Monastery** near Pyrgos is on the highest hill of Thira. It is rarely open to visitors, but the magnificent view from the top of the hill makes the climb worth it. It is on the hiking trail from Fira to Kamari. Not too far away is the **Panaghia Episcopi**, a church commissioned by the Byzantine Emperor Alexios I Komnenos at the end of the 11th century. The interior is worth seeing for its interesting architecture as well as its numerous frescoes. The honour of most spectacular church on the Thira arguably goes to **Timiou Stafrou**, a very traditional Greek Orthodox church in Perissa, one of the largest on in Santorini, with characteristic blue domes. It is right next to the beach, offering opportunities for idyllic pictures.



St. Nektarios chapel in the Profeta Elias Monastery

Do

Santorini's breathtaking volcanic landscape, with steep cliffs and smouldering craters, is what draws more adventurous travellers to the archipelago. It does not have water parks, theme parks, or zoos, but when strolling through narrow streets in villages such as Pyrgos or Oia gets monotonous, there are ample opportunities for hiking and water activities.

Hiking

There aren't as many dedicated footpaths as one might expect, and cycling or mountain biking infrastructure is absent entirely. That said, there are several hiking trails on Thira illustrating that quality is more important than quantity in this case.

The best example is the famous Fira to Oia trail that follows the crater ridge, and offers spectacular views of the caldera along the way. From Oia it is easy to take a ferry to the neighbouring islands Nea Kameni or Thirasia, which offer good hiking opportunities. The volcano craters of Nea Kameni in particular are worth seeing. Instead of taking the ferry from Oia, a connecting hiking trail branches off at Finikia for the Finikia to Cape Koloumpos trail. This 5 km long route passes through Finikia, and continues around the volcanic cones through vineyards, passing caves and a Minoan cistern along the way.



The spectacular caldera ridge hiking trail from Fira to Oia.

In the southern half of Thira, the most scenic route is the Pyrgos to Kamari trail, starting just south of Pyrgos and passing the highest point of the island at Profitis Ilias monastery. The descent passes the Zoodochos Pigis cave on the southern flank of the hill before reaching Kamari. From Kamari, the trail continues over the hill and passes the archaeological site of Ancient Thera, which is best visited in the morning. Descending the other side of the hill leads into Perissa. For those preferring an easier route with less climbing, the Perissa to Agios Georgios trail starts at the Basilica ruins of Perissa and follows the beach for 3 km. Continuing the walk to Exomytis is also possible, for a total length of 5 km, and it passes the necropolis of Ancient Eleusis on the way.

Beaches

Owing to Santorini's volcanic legacy, the island coastlines along the caldera edge are typically steep cliffs where there are no beaches. Instead, beaches are on the outer side of the semi-circular archipelago, most of them on Thira. A young archipelago on geological time scales, the sea hasn't had the time yet to erode the volcanic rocks fine sand, and therefore you won't find sandy beaches. Instead, beaches are generally composed of pebbles of varying sizes, and proper footwear is required to traverse them comfortably. An unusual feature of Thira is that eroding cliffs have greatly varying colours across locations, resulting in beaches that are equally colourful. The most common beach colours are black, white, and red. Some of the most interesting beaches are listed below.



A red pebble beach in the south of Thira.

- **Kamari Beach**, a black sand beach in Kamari, continues south in Perissa.
- **Red Beach** south of Akrotiri earns its name from the iron-rich sedimentary rocks in the cliff face towering above the water, as well as the red sand. It's quite crowded. Many distant yachts can be seen from the beach—it looks really romantic at sunset time. Great snorkelling - an abundance of sea life is present, as with Perissa.
- **White Beach** can be reached only from the sea; get there by boat from Red Beach or Akrotiri. There is no pier so the only way to get there is by getting off the boat and walking through waist-deep water. It is beautiful, but very small with only a few beach chairs and umbrellas and no facilities.
- **Vlychada nude beach** is popular with naturists.
- **Perissa — Perivolos — Agios Georgios beach** is a continuous beach with varying colours and sand/pebble sizes stretching from Perissa to Agios Georgios with a length of 3 km. It has beach bars and restaurants that makes it feel like a "beach day club".
- **Baxedes beach** is the main beach at the north side of Thira island. Baxedes is a peaceful place with black sand, much more like how Santorini was like before mass tourism discovered the island.

Culture

The oldest theatre on the archipelago is Fira's **White Door Theatre**, which plays local and Greek comedies. In the summer months, the **Open Air Cinema near Kamari** also offers a unique experience.

Scuba and snorkelling

Santorini has dive shops in Akrotiri, Perissa and Kamari. Prices are typically around €80 for two dives, including equipment rental, transport, and usually, a light lunch. The offerings are otherwise quite similar. Prices are sometimes lower when booked directly through dive shop, rather than through a travel agency.

Diving, visibility is amazing, but there are not as many fish as more popular scuba and snorkelling locations. Dive sites include a wreck near the volcano, caverns, reefs, as well as wall diving. The wall dive is the most interesting. Octopus are not uncommon. To minimize environmental damage, all dive shops go to the same locations (although not at the same time), with moorings shared by all the dive shops. If you want to go to a specific dive site, call ahead, and find out which dive shops are heading to which locations on which day (or ask to go to a specific location).

Recommended sites for snorkelling include Mesa Pigadia beach, somewhat out (some people recommended a diving buoy for boat safety), the beach south of Oia, as well as Perissa Rock (esp. somewhat further around the rock). There are supposed to be some nice spots between Perivolos and Vlichada Beach as well. The beach on Thirasia also has some reasonable snorkelling. Caldera Beach, near Akrotiri, has a few amazing snorkelling spots. When walking down to Caldera Beach (follow the signs to Santorini Dive Center), you will see some rock formations further out into the water. If you can find those once in the water, and swim to them, you will find wonderful snorkelling.

Virtually all beach-side shops will sell cheap, low-quality snorkelling gear (mask for around €10, fins for around €20).



Sunset seen through the Heart of Santorini



Buy

There is generally at least one supermarket in each village where the locals shop, for example Lidl near Mesaria and Sklavenitis in Fira, Mesaria, & Perissa. Otherwise there are plenty of *mini markets*, which are convenience stores that can be found near town centres and on secondary and tertiary roads. Expect prices there to be inflated by at least 25%.

Eat

Specialities

Santorini's volcanic soil, dry climate, and near absence of tree coverage has had its impact on the island's agriculture. It forced the cultivation of carefully selected variants of fruits and vegetables. Since the 1980s, several factors have contributed to the decline of the archipelago's agricultural diversity. The introduction of desalination plants has largely resolved the traditional water scarcity, which enabled cultivation of fruits and vegetables with higher yield that are not traditionally native to Santorini. The

growth in tourism has also led to farmland being sacrificed to build hotels, villas, and other tourist accommodation. And finally, the popularity of Santorini wines abroad has caused a shift from traditional crops to a near-monoculture of vineyards across the island since the early 2000s.

The result is that many Santorini specialities that used to be served in many restaurants on the archipelago, have now become extremely rare or extinct. The most infamous example is Santorini's **white aubergine**. White aubergines have fewer seeds than their mainland counterparts and a much sweeter taste. Dishes with white aubergines have a unique flavour, but in the 2020s they have become an increasingly rare product, only served in the most exclusive restaurants. Krinak in Finikia is one of the only restaurants still serving white aubergine puree.

Another famous Santorini speciality are **tomato keftedes**. These tomato fritters traditionally use Santorini's sweet cherry tomatoes and are served as appetisers or condiments, and consist of tomato slices in a batter of bell peppers, onions, mint, and aromatic herbs, deep fried in olive oil.

Fava is possibly the most popular Santorini speciality. It is a split-pea puree, usually served warm, that is topped with olive oil, lemon, and occasionally chopped onions. Onions are sometimes substituted for **capers** which are another traditional favourite on Santorini. Fava is considered a healthy comfort food by the locals, and it is served as a side dish or as a main dish with bread. It is sometimes also served with **chlorotyri**, a local cheese made from goat milk that is used in salads or spread on bread.



Tomato keftedes

As a resource-constrained island, livestock other than goats and donkeys is uncommon on Santorini, and meat dishes are not part of the traditional diet. One notable exception is **apochti**: pork loin salted and pickled before being air-dried in the heat of the summer sun. After drying, a mix of pepper and cinnamon is rubbed on the meat, and then cured. Apochti are used in different recipes, often accompanied with red wine. Nowadays meats are imported from the mainland to satisfy tourist expectations, and both souvlaki and gyros can be found in every tourist town.

Seafood is very popular, in particular grilled octopus and deep fried fish. Many traditional seafood restaurants along the coast have disappeared and converted into generic "Greek" tourist restaurants. Traditional restaurants can still be found in Vlychada, such as the Fisherman's House in the harbour, where fresh fish is served while watching small fishing vessels enter and leave the marina. Asking for the catch of the day is always a good idea!

For dessert, baklava can be found everywhere. **Kopania** are traditional Santorini sweets made of powdered barley rusks and mixed with raisins, sesame seeds, or other nuts. The dough is rolled in balls and sprinkled with roasted sesame seeds. Kopania can be found in traditional bakeries. Around Orthodox Easter, towards the end of April, a traditional sweet cheese pie called **melitinia** can also be found in bakeries. It is prepared in a wood-fired oven, using fresh mizithra cheese, sugar, and mastic powder.

Where to eat

The archipelago doesn't have many large supermarkets, but there are many smaller shops and convenience stores where food can be purchased to take away. Bakeries can be found in every town or village, and serve bread as well as a variety of pastries such as the traditional saganaki (fried cheese in filo pastry covered in honey) or spanakopita (spinach pie). These are good hearty options when hiking across the island.

There is no lack of restaurants, although the ones serving authentic Santorini cuisine are in decline, usually morphed into generic Greek restaurants aimed at a tourist clientele. The most extreme example is probably Oia, where Greek fast food at elevated prices is the norm in almost every restaurant. As a rule of thumb, look at the menu displayed outside: if the menu has moussaka but not fava, you're probably better off looking elsewhere.

Many restaurants overlooking the caldera in Oia, Imerovigli, Fira, Megalochori or Akrotiri will charge a premium for the view, especially those advertising "sunset views". Expect prices that are at least 30-50% higher than what is charged for comparable food in side streets a bit further away from the caldera. Stay away from places that are overtly commercial and instead visit family-run fish taverns near the smaller beaches and communities.

If you want to learn how to make Cycladic cuisine, [Kokkalo](#) in [Fira](#) offers cooking courses.

Drink

Water

Because the island receives so little rain, and has no rivers or lakes, fresh water is scarce. Prior to the early 1990s, water was delivered via tanker from Crete. However, most hotels and homes now have tap water from a few desalination plants scattered across the island. This water is potable and meets minimum EU safety standards. However, it is rather salty, and there are health concerns around its long-term consumption, so **most everyone drinks bottled water** while visiting. Bottled water is widely available in supermarkets and its price is regulated, which means it's relatively cheap at €2 for a 6-pack of 1.5L bottles. Dehydration is, together with sunburns, the most common health issue encountered on Santorini.

Wine

Santorini is one of Greece's most prominent wine regions, and the wines enjoy EU protected designation of origin (PDO). The dry soil and windy climate create wines that are well thought of, if not world famous. The island is famous for the *Assyrtiko* grape, which is grown as a shrub rather than a vine, and is visible in vineyards across the island.

The [Santorini Wine Museum](#) in [Vothonas](#) is a good place to educate yourself on the wine region. You can tour local wineries in [Megalochori](#) and [Pyrgos](#), and enjoy the local wines in practically every restaurant across the island.

Sleep

Santorini can be divided into the inner **caldera side**, where the villages like [Fira](#) and [Oia](#) are built on the cliff, and the **outer side**, which resembles the rest of the [Cyclades](#) islands.

Santorini is popular mainly for features of the caldera side, along the western edge of Thira. Many hotels here have terrific views of the caldera, volcano, the sea and sunsets. Most of the luxury resorts are on this side. There is of course a drawback to the caldera views: most of the hotels have many stairs. Some hotels do not offer any children's facilities or even accept children under 13, due to their dangerous location on the cliff. Instead, hotels tend to be oriented to couples and honeymooners. Note that not all hotels on the western side offer views, as some are in town.



The iconic windmill of [Oia](#)



The eastern side of Thira has many beach hotels, especially in [Kamari](#), that also attract a lot of tourists, mainly youngsters and families. These hotels usually offer larger rooms and pools than those on the other side of the island.

Keep in mind that the room rates are often set according to the view of the room, which makes the hotels on eastern side much cheaper than those on the western side.

Book your accommodation well in advance, as most hotels have no more than 20 rooms and fill up quickly.

Most hotels are closed during winter. They open during or after Greek Orthodox Easter (April or May) and usually close by the end of October. As in other [Greek Islands](#), July, August and September are considered high season.

Stay healthy

There are no hospitals on Santorini, but there is a clinic in [Fira](#) that is reasonably well equipped. Their phone number is ☎ [+30 228 602-2237](#). Smaller clinics can be found in [Emporio](#), [Kamari](#), [Oia](#), [Pirgos](#), and [Thirassia](#). For serious medical attention or emergencies, you are likely to be airlifted to [Athens](#). Let this be your reminder to get travel insurance!

The **UV index** on Santorini is 9 or 10 throughout the year which is considered **extreme**. SPF 50 sunscreen is an absolute necessity, even under T-shirts! Avoid going out into the sun during the hottest hours of the day (12:00 - 15:00). Don't be deceived by the cool sea breeze that lowers the temperature, the sun burns regardless.



A European cat snake, despite its dangerous looks completely harmless to humans



Compared to mainland Greece, there are no dangerous fauna to be concerned about on Santorini. The 2 species of snakes on the island, the leopard snake (*Zamenis situla*) and cat snake (*Telescopus fallax*), are completely harmless to humans. There are also 2 species of scorpions which have the tendency to hide in cracks in stone walls, but are likewise harmless. The only significant health hazard are drunk tourists, who can be found in abundance in the touristic areas of major towns between midnight and the early morning hours.

Stay safe

Be aware of rental scams, especially with agencies working only with motorbikes and ATVs. There are a lot of rental agencies, and some of them are ready to cheat. They will offer faulty motorbikes or ATVs for a lower price, but in case of accident they will demand that the customer pay for the whole cost of damage. They are offering only basic insurance but will present it like full insurance. Also, there is a possibility of serious injuries. These rental agencies aggressively attract tourists and offer lower prices than others. Employees in front of these type of agencies will be loud and ready to promise everything until the contract is signed. Check the vehicle before making any decision: their vehicles are in many cases dusty, dirty and look old.



Bell tower of the Cathedral of Saint John the Baptist in Fira

Santorini is relatively crime-free: you are quite unlikely to be pick-pocketed. On the other hand, you may feel you have been ripped off by some restaurant or bar bills. Remember not to shop at stores or order at restaurants without posted prices.

The cliffs and low walls guarding large drops pose a danger to children. The elderly may encounter problems with the many steps.

Cave exploring can be fun, but do not deviate from the paths because of the unstable rocks made of tufa. Don't linger under cliffs, as they are prone to rockslides.

Santorini is vulnerable to **earthquakes**. A major earthquake devastated the island in 1956, leading to substantial reconstruction efforts. In 2025, a swarm of smaller quakes closed attractions and services islandwide as a precaution. Take note of the assembly points set up in each settlement. In the event of an earthquake, obey orders from officials, and be prepared to evacuate.

Connect

There are some local radio stations in Santorini, mainly in Greek language. Turn your radio to Volcano Radio at 106.4 MHz and Top Melody Fm Radio at 104.9 MHz.

Internet

Free Wifi is available in most cafes, beach bars, and hotels. You can find internet cafes in [Kamari](#), [Perissa](#), [Fira](#) (wireless access also available) and in [Oia](#).

There is a booth selling prepaid SIM cards in the Arrivals hall of the airport, for durations of 3, 7, or 10 days. The default package is €25 for a data volume of 8 GB for 7 days. Although there is supposedly 5G, wireless routers *do not connect* with prepaid SIM cards (as of 2022) and only offer 2G (EDGE) connection without data. Try the SIM card in your wireless device before purchasing to verify that it works properly. Santorini, being part of Greece, offers EU roaming free of charge to visitors with an EU SIM card.

There is only cellular coverage on Thira and Therassia, not on the uninhabited islands.

Go next

Ferries are available to [Anafi](#), [Chalki](#), [Folegandros](#), [Heraklion \(Crete\)](#), [Ios](#), [Karpathos](#), [Kasos](#), [Katapola](#), [Kos](#), [Koufonissi](#), [Milos](#), [Mykonos](#), [Naxos](#), [Paros](#), [Piraeus](#), [Rafina](#), [Rhodes](#), [Serifos](#), [Sifnos](#), [Sikinos](#), [Sitia](#), [Syros](#), [Thirasia](#), and [Tinos](#).

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